

THE PASHTUN TRIBAL CONFEDERATIONS

Durrani Ghilzai Karlani Sarbani Ghurghusht Bettani

The Pashtun world is often described through tribes. But above the level of individual tribes, traditional genealogical systems also speak of larger groupings commonly described as tribal confederations.

A confederation brings together multiple tribes within a broader historical or genealogical framework, reflecting shared traditions, political relationships, genealogical narratives, regional connections, and historical alliances. However, these structures should not be mistaken for a single centralized organization or state.

A TRADITIONAL FRAMEWORK

One influential historical framework identifies three major Pashtun confederations: Durrani, Ghilzai, and Karlani. As noted in scholarly literature such as **Encyclopaedia Iranica**, these groupings structure much of the ethnographic and historical discussion surrounding Pashtun society.¹

At the same time, classifications differ across sources. Traditional genealogical systems also utilize broader categories such as Sarbani, Ghurghusht, and Bettani alongside Karlani. These classifications overlap depending on the source and genealogical tradition.

DURRANI / ABDALI

The Durrani confederation (historically known by the older name Abdali) is among the most prominent political groupings in Afghan history. As detailed by Daniel Balland in

Encyclopaedia Iranica, the confederation historically consists of ten Pashtun tribes organized into two primary leagues: Panjpāy and Zīrak (Jīrak).²

The confederation encompasses prominent tribal branches such as the Popalzai, Barakzai, Alikozai, Achakzai, and Alizai. Its political prominence expanded dramatically following the establishment of the Durrani Empire by Ahmad Shah Durrani in the eighteenth century.

GHILZAI / GHILJI

The Ghilzai (also written Ghilji or Ghilzay) form another major Pashtun confederation historically associated with eastern and southeastern Afghanistan. Early historical references appear in sixteenth-century chronicles, and the confederation subsequently played a vital role in regional politics and social history.³

Regarding deeper origins, historical writers have proposed various hypotheses—such as connections with Turkish or Khalaj groups or the Hephthalites. As scholarly research emphasizes, these proposals remain matters of historical speculation rather than proven biological descent.

KARLANI AND THE ORAKZAI CONNECTION

Karlani is another major category in traditional Pashtun classification, historically associated with eastern and southeastern Afghanistan and adjoining areas of northwestern Pakistan. Traditional genealogies place numerous tribes within Karlani, including the Afridi, Orakzai, Wazir, Mehsud, and Bangash.⁴

For this book, Orakzai identity is traditionally situated within the Karlani genealogical grouping. Recognizing this traditional placement provides cultural and historical context while upholding rigorous scholarly standards that distinguish between genealogy and biological proof.

CONFEDERATIONS ARE NOT STATES

Confederations helped organize historical memory, preserve traditions of common ancestry, and reflect political alliances. However, they did not function as centralized states or modern governments. Individual tribes maintained local autonomy, cooperating during certain epochs and competing during others.

Understanding these layers—from Pashtun identity down to confederation, tribe, clan, lineage, and family—allows us to appreciate the structural complexity of Pashtun history without reducing it to a single rigid family tree.⁵

IDENTITY · CONFEDERATION · TRIBE · LINEAGE

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

The concept of tribal confederations teaches us that Pashtun identity is built on layers of connection rather than a single monolithic authority. By honoring both traditional genealogies and historical scholarship, we gain a truer appreciation of how our communities formed, adapted, and endured across the centuries.